ADVANCE PRAISE FOR THE BOOK

‘This is a superb work of historical scholarship, which can be read for its intrinsic interest and for the profound resonances it has for our own times. It is a dual biography, of a remarkable individual and of a daring commercial enterprise he founded. With an enviable mastery of sources in Tamil and in English, A.R. Venkatachalapathy takes us through these two interwoven careers, of the radical and recklessly courageous nationalist V.O. Chidambaram Pillai and his Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company that so bravely (and perhaps recklessly) challenged the economic and political hegemony of the British Empire. In a mundane sense, both these careers ended in failure and tragedy; it is the historian’s singular achievement to have brought back to us the dignity, courage and resolution that underlay them’—Ramachandra Guha

‘“I will not fear,” said VOC. “I will not weary.” How, through the gusty winds of political persecution and the lashing waves of financial misfortunes, the patriot-shipper faced his challenges is a story Venkatachalapathy tells us movingly and unforgettably. A breakthrough in archival retrieval and historical narration’—Gopalkrishna Gandhi

‘*Swadeshi Steam* is the result of Chalapathy’s four-decade-long labour of love. Perseverance and pursuit, both essential traits in a historian, are seen in ample measure. It is more than the biography of V.O. Chidambaram or the history of the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company. Corroborated by a range of rare documents, it conclusively establishes Tamilnadu’s signal contribution to the Indian freedom struggle. Replete with historical surprises, Chalapathy’s fascinating narrative style and language, imbued with a wide range of emotions, makes this book a compelling read’—Perumal Murugan, author of *One Part Woman*

‘With his corporate challenge to the mighty British Raj, V.O. Chidambaram Pillai altered the tenor of the Indian freedom movement. A.R.